



Exploring Inclusive College Opportunities for your Child with an Intellectual Disability

Angie Kniery and Beth Foraker – December 2018



COLLEGE
JUST AHEAD

The reason we're here today... meet Joe & Patrick!



Why does Going to College Matter?

Look at these outcomes of those who attended college...

- More stable relationships
- More civically engaged
- Better job opportunities - which means better money
- Better health
- Happier life
- Better life outcomes across every measurable metric

Why would we deny an entire segment of society access to this opportunity?

HIGHER EDUCATION IS ABOUT OPPORTUNITY. THIS IS ABOUT FREEDOM.

Currently 83% of people with intellectual disabilities are UNemployed -- compared with 4% for the rest of us.



Getting Started



It's never too early to begin!

- Teaching independent living skills
- Fostering independence at home
- Spending time away from you, the parent/s
- Overnight experiences: camp, field trips, friends + family
- Using a smart phone and email
- Giving your child opportunities to make their own choices: lead their IEP, have opportunities to speak in public, or be a leader in a group



Differences between K-12 and Higher Education

- IDEA is a legal mandate that a free, appropriate education (FAPE) is provided to all students, in the least restrictive environment
- Services are provided as indicated in an agreed upon IEP
- Student has a team of people to work with
- Accommodations and supports are provided via ADA and the 504 Act, and require proof of disability
- Services are provided only as a result of self-advocacy by student
- Student is responsible for much of his or her own experience: course selection, requesting supports, etc.

There are many publications about these differences. Think College just released one called [*Understanding the Differences between High School and College*](#).



How to get ready: Building the resume

- Start planning in middle school/Freshman year
- All educators need to know that college is your goal...starting in kindergarten! *It is OK to add “attending college” as a goal to the IEP.*
- Your child needs to plan too...**they can't be what they can't see**...share videos and stories.
- Help your child have an awareness of strengths and challenges
- ACTIVITIES- sports, art, clubs, things your student enjoys independently from family and school
- Volunteer and work opportunities
- Transportation experience
- Create a Circle of Support: [Janice Fialka-Feldman](#), [Micah Feldman](#), and many friends!

Help your child grow in awareness about his/her disability.

Your child can learn the skill of self-advocacy.

Give your child opportunities to be around other students with disabilities.

Give him or her an opportunity to understand that he or she has a disability and has strengths and challenges associated with that disability.

Help him or her see that it is OK to ask for support.

Help him or her move from unawareness to self-acceptance to self-love and eventually pride.



Teaching self-care skills



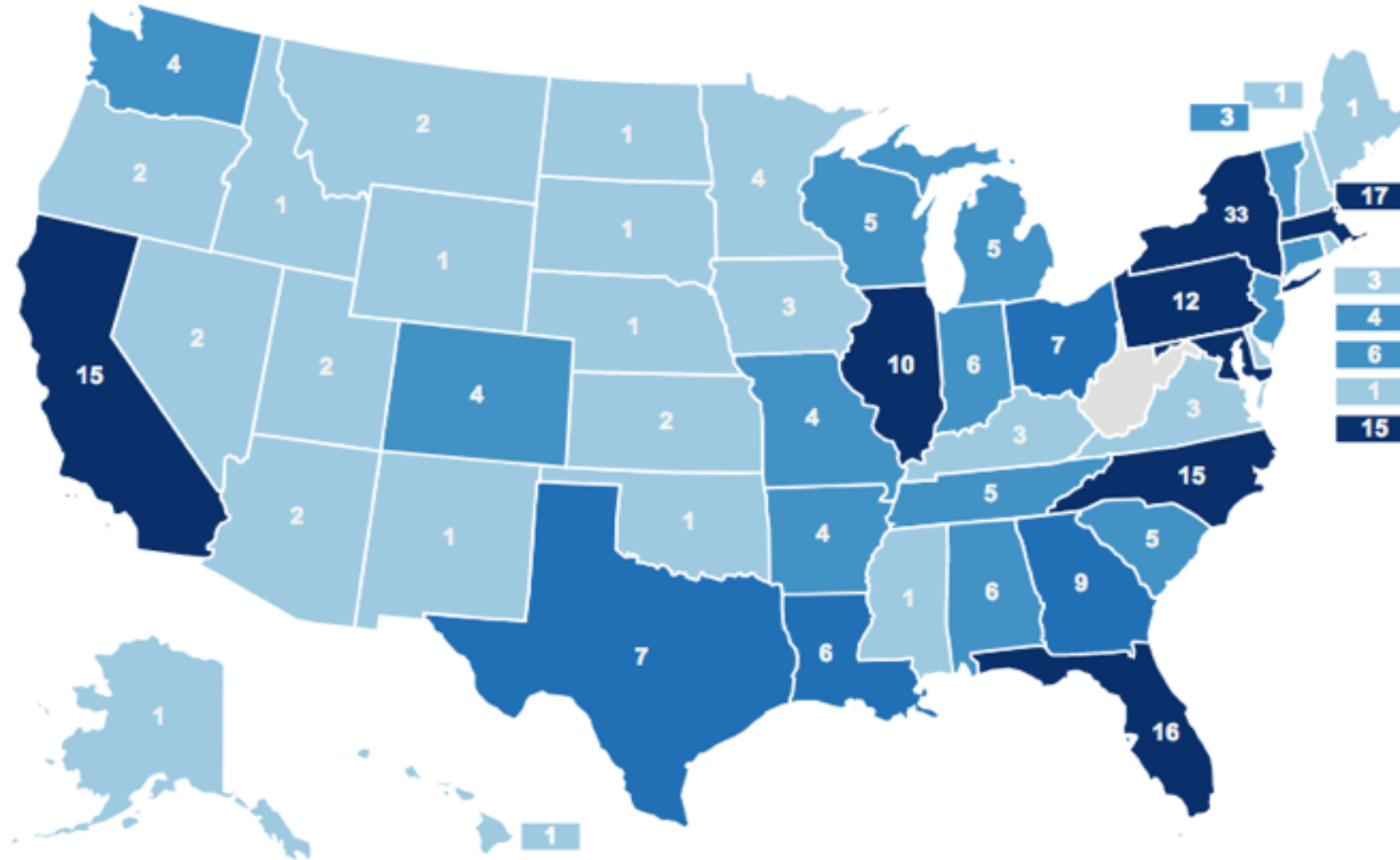
Health and Medical needs

- Daily hygiene
- Medications
- Medical History
- Using technology to document and keep track of these things
- What to do in an emergency

Exploring College Options

- [Think College](#)
- [Think College College Search](#)
- Facebook: Families Think College (Parents perspective)
- College Websites
- State of the Art Conference on Postsecondary Education and Individuals with Intellectual Disabilities
- You Tube (e.g., [Beyond Academics](#))
- Webinars
- Disability-specific websites (e.g., National Down Syndrome Society, Williams Syndrome Association)
- [PACER Center](#)





NUMBER OF PROGRAMS



College Search Database

The Think College Map! It is always changing and growing. The Think College Program database is a good resource to see what programs are out there:

<https://thinkcollege.net/college-search>



31 Flavors! Every College Has A Flavor...

Consider the kind of school your child might want:

- There are **HUGE** schools and **medium** schools and small schools.
- There are 2 year and 4 year schools.
- Some schools have a huge emphasis on sports.
- Fraternities and sororities are a part of some campuses.
- Some schools are located in a city, others are more rural.
- The location of the school could impact access to transportation.
- Some schools have extensive on-campus housing options; others do not.
- Maybe some schools are close by and others are not...



All Programs are Different

- Distance from home
- Residential housing options
- Length of program varies: 2 years, 3 years, 4 years
- Class opportunities (regular college class with support, supported living classes)
- Individualized planning
- Guardianship
- Career planning and preparation options
- Level of support
 - Peer support
 - Paid/ unpaid support
 - Expectations



But is it a CTP, or Comprehensive Transition Program?

A CTP is a degree, certificate, or non-degree program for students with intellectual disabilities that meet specific criteria. If students with intellectual disabilities are attending a CTP, *they are able to use federal financial aid* to help pay for attendance.

CTPs are offered by a college or career school, and are approved by the U.S. Department of Education. They support students with intellectual disabilities who want to continue academic, career, and independent living instruction to prepare for gainful employment.

CTPs were initially described and defined in the Higher Education Opportunity Act of 2008.

CTPs can be located in the Think College database by selecting “*Offers Financial Aid*” and appear in the listing with an *icon with a dollar sign and graduation cap*.

The screenshot displays the Think College database interface. On the left sidebar, under the 'PROGRAM FEATURES' section, the filter 'Offers Financial Aid' is highlighted with a red circle. The main content area shows the details for the 'EAGLES' program at Auburn University. The program description states: 'EAGLES (Education to Accomplish Growth in Life Experiences for Success) is a comprehensive transition program for students with intellectual disabilities. The EAGLES program includes Auburn University credit-bearing courses, as well as program courses focused on improving students' independent living and employment outcomes. Students participating in EAGLES are integrated into university life and academic courses. The EAGLES program includes... Read more'. Contact information for Dr. Karen Rabren, Interim Director, is provided. At the bottom right, a graduation cap icon is circled in red.

Address	Phone	Web	Contact	Email
EAGLES 2084 Haley Center Auburn University, AL 36849	334-844-2082	https://web.auburn.edu/institute/Eagles/Default.aspx	Dr. Karen Rabren, Interim Director	rabrenka@auburn.edu

What do some of these programs look like?

Program A:

- All students are supported to learn numerous ways to get around campus until they can do so independently
- *Every* course is accessible - *all* professors are on board
Why? Professors teach better and *all* students benefit.
- Peer mentors in place for academics, exercise/nutrition, social
- Paid jobs every semester based on student interest - job skills embedded in coaching; uses the salary to learn budgeting skills
- Individual student interest and participation is supported and encouraged
- “Inclusive living” means all students in program are placed with typical students in dorms on campus

What do some of these programs look like...continued

Program B:

- “Inclusive living” means students are taught about housekeeping, cooking, shopping embedded in direct teaching, and they have supported living within the dorm
- Program may be 2, 3, or 4 years in length
- Some required courses are offered only to students in the program and are taught by direct instruction; students also take courses from the university course catalog that are preapproved
- There is a community of learners and many social opportunities, like Special Olympics participation year round where students have the option to be coaches for the younger participants
- Peer mentors are available as study partners
- Supported internships and jobs off campus - includes learning public transportation



What do some of these programs look like...continued

Program C:

- Program length is 2 years
- Does not include inclusive living – only option is to be a commuter student
- Offers support for some on-campus jobs/internships
- Courses are available with support
- Enrollment may be funded with transition program monies, or considered a dual enrollment program
- Students have access to every on-campus activity or club, and people with disabilities are invited to take on leadership roles
- Many internship and employment opportunities available





UNIVERSITY

Visiting Colleges

- General College Open House & Tour
- Program Open House – these fill up! Call early!
- Individual Visits
- Talking to Program Director
- Great way to get a taste of what's possible

Keep track of what you learn using this guide, developed by Think College:
[Conducting a College Search](#)





You can't be what you can't see...

this is really true for students with intellectual disabilities.

Offer the opportunity to your child and see what your child thinks...they may surprise you.

Follow their lead...and help them to see what is possible.

Have your child talk to other students in programs.



First Semester Scrapbook – What Does College Look Like?



College means sharing your life with new friends.



Living on your own with support!



Flying home for Thanksgiving – solo!



Participating on campus in clubs!



Exploring a new city!



Working out!



What are you and your child hoping for?

There can be so many opportunities and possible outcomes for students who attend college. Here are just a few to consider... *know before you go!*

- Are there internships available, and what kind?
 - Paid/unpaid
 - Types of internships
- What happens upon program completion/graduation? Is there a certificate or degree to be earned?
- How many students get and keep jobs?
- What post-graduation services are available?
- Where do graduates go when they leave college?
- Is this school in an inclusive community, one that's ready to support a person at work, at home, or in continued learning?



Additional Resources

- **Think College website:** <https://thinkcollege.net>
 - A clearinghouse of information and support for those interested in higher education for students with ID; also serves as the National Coordinating Center which provides support, coordination, training, and evaluation services for Transition and Postsecondary Education Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities (TPSIDs).
- **Intelligent Lives website:** <https://intelligentlives.org/>
 - This website features the movie, Intelligent Lives, and many resources to support its use as a tool for education and advocacy. This film challenges what it means to be intelligent, and points to a future in which people of all abilities can fully participate in higher education, meaningful employment, and intimate relationships.
- **National Center for College Students with Disabilities:** <http://www.nccsdonline.org>
 - NCCSD is the only federally-funded national center in the U.S. for college and graduate students with **any** type of disability, chronic health condition, or mental or emotional illness. We also have information for parents, faculty, and anyone working with college students
- **Division on Career Development and Transition at CEC:** <http://community.cec.sped.org/dcdt/home>
 - DCDT promotes national and international efforts to improve the quality of and access to, career/vocational and transition services, increases the participation of education in career development and transition goals, and influences policies affecting career development and transition services for persons with disabilities.

Thank you! Feel free to contact us- or each other!

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**Families Think College (closed)
Facebook page: just ask to join!**

